

The New York Times, October 14, 2004

What Women Want?

WOMEN AS GAME developers? For many, this would sound as weird as male nannies. But male nannies exist, and so do women game developers. Still don't believe us? Here's what Katie Hafner of The New York Times has to report on the women behind some of the world's most popular games.



Denise Fulton spent much of her childhood playing computer games. At 8, while growing up in Ohio, she was already playing Zork, Adventure and other text-based games. And the fascination continued into her adult years.

So it is not surprising that today Ms. Fulton, 34, is an executive producer at Ion Storm, a video game company in Austin, Tex., where she is overseeing the next installment in the popular Deus Ex series.

The surprising part is how rare Ms. Fulton is. Behind the computer screen, as in front of it, video games are a man's world.

Informal estimates put the percentage of women in the industry at around 10 percent, and even then, most tend to be in jobs in customer service, marketing and quality assurance. Relatively few women work as game designers and producers, and even fewer are programmers.

"It's not so much that women look at the industry and discard the idea," said Sheri Graner Ray, a senior game designer at Sony Online Entertainment. "It's that the game industry just never even comes up on their radar."

The reason has to do with a truism about the computer game industry. Those who work in the industry tend to enter their jobs as avid gamers. And playing video games, especially those loaded with graphic violence, has been a male pursuit. According to the NPD Group, a market research firm based in New York, some 81 percent of video-game players are male.

"It's a chicken-or-egg thing," said Ms. Fulton, who sees a lot of résumés in her job, almost all from men. "If more women were playing games, they might get interested in games as a medium and might choose to pursue that as a career. But it's still stigmatized as a boy thing."

Now, though, manufacturers are starting to think about making games that are more appealing to women, like the Sims, a role-playing game that is viewed as one of the most popular games among women.

"Do women not play games because the games that are out there are designed for men, or is it just that women really don't like computer games?" said Elizabeth Sweedyk, an assistant professor of computer science at Harvey Mudd College in Claremont, Calif. "My guess is they don't like the games that are out there."

Manufacturers understand there is a huge untapped portion of the market. "They've realized they have to appeal to women," said David Riley, senior manager at NPD. And as more games are marketed to, and played by, girls and women, more women eventually may end up choosing a career in the industry.

Until then, though, people like Ms. Fulton, and like Nicky Robinson, a programmer, will be the exceptions.

To read the entire story, please visit, www.snipurl.com/gamewomen

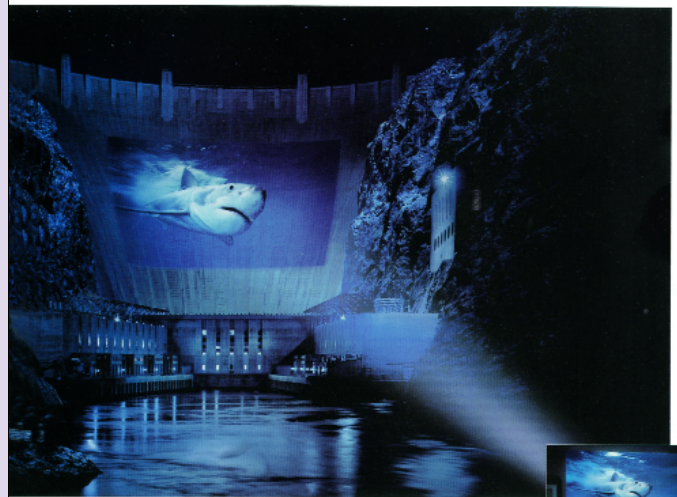


■ The Disappearing Act...

is what the guys at Apple have successfully brought about. The iMac amalgamates the display and the processing unit into one body. The slim 'model' here in the ad does make quite an impression!

EPSON®

Feel free to try this at home.



The New Epson Home Projector. Larger-than-life entertainment for your living room wall.

This is huge. Because now, any evening can be transformed into a night of mind-blowing entertainment. The Epson projector turns your living room into your own private theater for movies, TV shows, sporting events and even video games. Here's why. Projects images to fit any wall • Crystal-clear image quality optimized for video • Easily connects to your DVD, VCR, cable box, gaming system, camcorder or PC • 16:9 wide-screen format • EDTV ready • Compact and portable. 800-GO-EPSON • epson.com/home theater



Epson is a registered trademark of Seiko Epson Corp. Epson and the Epson logo are registered trademarks of Epson America, Inc. © 2004 Epson America, Inc. All rights reserved.

■ Sharp Attack

The message hits home loud and clear— that the Epson projector just has a one-point mission—mind-blowing entertainment that's crystal clear in this ad's depiction.